

Document 9: Minor Burns (First-Degree)

Metadata

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- **Category:** First Aid, Dermatological
- **Keywords:** burn, thermal injury, first-degree burn, sunburn, skin redness

Definition of Minor Burns

A first-degree burn is a superficial thermal injury that affects only the outermost layer of the skin (the epidermis). Common causes include mild sunburns, brief contact with hot objects, or splashing hot liquids.

Symptoms of Minor Burns

Symptoms are localized to the affected area and usually heal within 3 to 6 days. They include:

- Redness of the skin
- Mild pain and tenderness to the touch
- Minor swelling
- Dry skin that may peel as it heals (blisters do not form in first-degree burns)

Treatment and Management for Minor Burns

Immediate and proper first aid can reduce damage and pain:

1. **Cool the burn:** Hold the burned area under cool (not cold) running water or apply a cool, wet compress for about 10 minutes or until the pain subsides. Never apply ice directly to a burn.
2. **Moisturize:** Once cooled, apply a soothing lotion containing aloe vera or a mild moisturizer to prevent drying.
3. **Protect:** Cover the burn with a sterile, non-adhesive gauze bandage. Wrap it loosely to avoid putting pressure on burned skin.
4. **Pain relief:** Take over-the-counter pain relievers (ibuprofen, acetaminophen) if needed.
5. **Note:** Never apply butter, oil, or toothpaste to a burn, as these trap heat and can cause infection.

When to Seek Medical Attention for Minor Burns

A patient should seek emergency care or consult a doctor if:

- The burn covers a large area of the body (larger than 3 inches in diameter).
- The burn is located on the face, hands, feet, groin, buttocks, or over a major joint.
- Blisters develop, or the skin looks leathery, charred, or white (indicating a more severe second or third-degree burn).
- Signs of infection appear during healing (oozing pus, increased pain, red streaking).

